

C-36 Plumbing Contractor — Licensing Checklist

California Contractors State License Board (CSLB) · pathtotrades.com · Updated March 2026

Timeline	Total Cost	Bond Required	Workers' Comp
4–12 months	\$900–\$2,000+	\$25,000	Exemption available (until 2028)

Step 1: Verify 4 Years Plumbing Experience

Before applying · \$0

■ **OWNER-BUILDER TRAP: Homeowner-signed verifications flagged for audit ~100%**

- Certification of Work Experience form (supervisor-signed)
- W-2s, pay stubs, tax returns (4 years)
- Must include: water supply, drainage, gas piping, fixtures

Tip: If your old boss won't sign, have multiple backup verifiers ready.

Step 2: Submit CSLB Application

1 day + 8–12 week wait · \$450

- Completed CSLB application for C-36 classification
- Experience forms attached
- \$450 fee — check or money order

Tip: CSLB verifies ~3% of claims — if audited, they want 4 years of paychecks.

Step 3: Fingerprinting (Live Scan)

1 day · \$49–\$80

- Government photo ID
- CSLB Live Scan form

Tip: Submit immediately — runs in parallel with app processing.

Step 4: Prepare for & Pass 2 Exams

1–3 months · \$150–\$500

■ **KEY STEP — Law & Business is where most people fail**

- Prep course or self-study materials
- Law & Business: 115 Qs, 3.5 hrs, 72% to pass
- C-36 Trade: 100 Qs, 3.5 hrs, 72% to pass

Tip: Law & Business: mechanics liens, payroll taxes. Trade: CA Plumbing Code.

Step 5: Complete Asbestos Open-Book Exam

1–2 hours · \$0

- Completed Asbestos Open-Book Exam & Verification Form

Tip: Mandatory — CSLB cannot issue license without it.

Step 6: File \$25,000 Bond + Insurance

1–3 days · \$250–\$600/yr + WC

■ **Bond is \$25K (not \$15K) since Jan 2023**

- \$25,000 surety bond certificate
- BQI bond if applicable
- Workers' comp certificate (or exemption until 2028)

Tip: WC expansion delayed to 2028 but CSLB already flagging renewals without it.

Step 7: Pay License Fee

1–2 weeks · \$200

- \$200 payment (\$350 non-sole owner)

Tip: CSLB doesn't require CE for C-36, but industry (PHCC, GCs) increasingly expects it.

Cost Breakdown

Item	Cost	When Due
CSLB application fee	\$450	With application
Live Scan fingerprinting	\$49–\$80	During processing
Exam prep course	\$150–\$500	Before exams
Contractor bond premium (annual)	\$250–\$600/yr	Before license issued
Workers' comp (recommended)	\$800–\$2,000+/yr	Before license issued
Initial license fee	\$200–\$350	After passing exams
TOTAL FIRST YEAR	\$900–\$2,000+	
Renewal (every 2 years)	\$450 + bond + WC	Before expiration

This checklist is for informational purposes only and is not legal advice. Verify all requirements at cslb.ca.gov before submitting your application. Bond amounts and fees are current as of March 2026.

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